

OMRAN K. SAFI

PhD Student, Cognitive Psychology
University of British Columbia

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EDUCATION

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| Doctor of Philosophy in Cognitive Psychology
University of British Columbia
Supervisor: Dr. Daniela Palombo
Thesis: On the Construction of Duration in Retrospect: The Relationship Between What and When in Memory (<i>in progress</i>) | 2023-27 |
| Master of Arts in Cognitive Psychology
University of British Columbia
Supervisor: Dr. Daniela Palombo
Thesis: Investigating the effects of emotion on temporal duration memory using naturalistic virtual reality | 2021-23 |
| Bachelor of Arts in Psychology
University of British Columbia
Specializing in Cognitive Psychology | 2020 |
| High School Diploma
Point Grey Secondary
Graduated with honors | 2015 |

AWARDS & ACCOMPLISHMENTS

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| Canada Graduate Scholarship – Doctoral
Natural Sciences and Engineering Research Council of Canada (NSERC) <ul style="list-style-type: none">Amount: \$40,000 | 2025-2028 |
| President's Academic Excellence Initiative PhD Award
University of British Columbia <ul style="list-style-type: none">Amount: \$1,215 | 2025/26 |
| Graduate Travel Award
Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting <ul style="list-style-type: none">Amount: \$750 (USD) | 2025 |

Graduate Student Travel Award University of British Columbia, Department of Psychology • Amount: \$650	2025
Graduate Student Travel Award University of British Columbia, Faculty of Graduate and Postdoctoral Studies • Amount: \$500	2024
Graduate Fellowship University of British Columbia, Department of Psychology • Amount: \$7,784	2024/25
Dean of Arts Graduate Student Research Award University of British Columbia, Faculty of Arts • Amount: \$1000	2023/24
Four Year Doctoral Fellowship University of British Columbia • Amount: \$18,200	2023-27
Graduate Fellowship University of British Columbia, Department of Psychology • Amount: \$2,500	2023/24
President's Academic Excellence Initiative PhD Award University of British Columbia • Amount: \$1,215	2023/24
Graduate Student Travel Award University of British Columbia, Department of Psychology • Amount: \$650	2023
Graduate Student Travel Award University of British Columbia, Faculty of Graduate and Postdoctoral Studies • Amount: \$500	2023
Faculty of Arts Graduate Award University of British Columbia, Department of Psychology • In recognition of academic achievement • Amount: \$13,500	2022
Faculty of Arts Graduate Award University of British Columbia, Department of Psychology • In recognition of academic achievement	2021

- Amount: \$15,000

PUBLICATIONS

Paper – Safi, O.K., Shi, Y., Lin, T., Yu, T., Wilson, I.S., Madan, C.R., Palombo, D.J. (2025). Evaluative Conditioning Using Virtual Reality Events. *Cognition and Emotion*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02699931.2025.2528928>

Paper – Bontkes, O.R., Safi, O.K., Lacusta, S., Wilson, I., & Palombo, D.J. (under review). Emotion Differentially Modulates Phenomenological Ratings and Narrative Descriptions of Mental Imagery in Episodic Future Thoughts. *Emotion*.

Paper - Safi, O. K., Shi, Y., Madan, C. R., Lin, T., & Palombo, D. J. (2023). The effects of emotion on retrospective duration memory using virtual reality. *Psychological Research*, 1-13. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s00426-023-01909-6>

Paper - Petrucci, A.S, McCall, C, Schofield, G, Wardell, V, Safi O.K, & Palombo, D.J. (2025). The relationship between environmentally induced emotion and memory for a naturalistic virtual experience. *Cognition and Emotion*. <https://doi.org/10.1080/02699931.2024.2333067>

Paper – Balance, B.C., Tuen, Y., Petrucci, A.S, Orwig, W., Safi, O.K., Madan, C. R., Palombo, D. J. (2022). Imagining Emotional Events Benefits Future-Oriented Decisions. *Quarterly Journal of Experimental Psychology*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/17470218221086637>

Paper – Safi, O. K., Tommasi, M., Sun, B., Thornley, J., Dodani, A. (2020). Carbon Footprint Information Promotes Sustainable Food Choices. UBC SEEDS. <https://open.library.ubc.ca/cIRcle/collections/undergraduateresearch/18861/items/1.0392724>

PRESENTATIONS

Presentation (2024) – Of What and When: Memory Content and Recalled Duration (UBC Cognitive Area Workshop)

Presentation (2023) – Investigating the Effects of Emotion on Temporal Duration Memory Using Naturalistic Virtual Reality (UBC Cognitive Area Workshop)

Presentation (2023) – Immersive Affective Dilation: Investigating Temporal Duration Memory Using Virtual Reality (UBC Psychfest 2023)

Presentation (2020) – Tracking Independent Information Signals Across Regions of Interest. (UBC Cognitive Area Workshop)

INVITED TALKS & GUEST LECTURES

Guest Lecture (2025) – Remembering Time (UBC Psychology 333 Course – Memory: Historical, Clinical, & Cognitive Perspectives)

Invited Talk (2024) – The Virtual Sandbox – A Novel Paradigm for Investigating Memory (UBC DMCBH Mindscape)

- Awarded most engaging presentation
- Second place for best talk

Invited Talk (2023) – Bridging the Gap; Studying the Effects of Emotion on Memory for Time Using Virtual Reality. (Virtual Reality as a tool for Cognition, Behaviour, and Health)

Invited Talk (2023) – The Sweet Spot of Memory (UBC Neuroscience 201 Course)

Guest Lecture (2023) – Conducting Cognitive Science Research (UBC Psychology 309 Course – Cognitive Processes)

Invited Talk (2020) – Tracking Independent Information Signals Across Regions of Interest (Memory for Events Lab, University of Alberta)

CONFERENCE WORKS

Talk (2026) –Safi, O.K.*, Lin, C., Kimberley Marty & Palombo, D.J. – Divided Space, Extended Time: How Spatial Boundaries Shape Retrospective Duration Memory. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*. *presenting author

- Received Stephen Lindsay Award for Best Presentation

Poster (2026) –Oliver Bontkes*, Safi, O.K., Lacusta, S., Wilson, I. & Palombo, D.J. – Emotion Differentially Modulates Phenomenological Ratings and Narrative Descriptions of Mental Imagery in Episodic Future Thoughts. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*. *presenting author

Poster (2026) – Lin, C., Thorpe, A., Safi, O.K., & Palombo, D.J. – Memory in Motion: Effects of Movement Dynamics on Retrospective Duration Estimates. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*.

Poster (2026) – Thorpe, A., Lin, C., Safi, O.K., & Palombo, D.J. – Navigating Virtual Environments: Examining Psychomotor Patterns in Depression. *UBC Psychology Undergraduate Conference*.

Poster (2026) – Safi, O.K., Lin, C., Marty, K., & Palombo, D.J. – When Space Divides, Time Expands: The Role of Boundaries in Retrospective Duration. *Cognitive Neuroscience Society 2026 Annual Meeting*.

Poster (2025) – Safi, O.K., Wilson, I. S., Marty, K., Palombo, D.J. – In Search of Time: Memory Contents Influence Subjective Duration Memory. *Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting*.

- Received Graduate Travel Award (\$750 USD)

Talk (2025) – Safi, O.K. & Palombo, D.J. – Of What and When: Memory Contents and Retrospective Duration. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*.

Poster (2025) – Safi, O.K., Bontkes, O. R., Palombo, D.J. – Making Time for the Future: Effects of Emotion of Duration in the Mind’s Eye. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*.

Poster (2024) – Safi, O.K., Bontkes, O.R., Palombo, D.J. – Making Time for the Future: Effects of Emotion on Duration in the Mind’s Eye. *Psychonomic Society Annual Meeting*.

- Invited Workshop – Leading Edge Workshop of Future Thinking

Talk (2024) – Safi, O.K., Shi Y., Lin T., Madan, C.R., Palombo, D.J. - Tugging on Time Using Virtual Reality; The Effects of Emotion on Retrospective Duration Memory. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*.

Poster (2024) - Safi, O.K.*, Shi Y., Lin T., Yu, T., Grewall, A., Madan, C.R., Palombo, D.J. – Bridging the Gap; A Novel Paradigm for Investigating Memory. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference*.

Talk (2024) – Palombo, D.J.,* Safi, O.K., Cocquyt, C., Wardell, V. - The Temporal Tapestry of Emotional Memory: Untangling the Threads. *Cognitive Neuroscience Society*. *presenting author

Poster (2024) – Grewall, A., Yu, T., Wilson, I., Safi, O.K., Palombo, D.J. – Cued Recall of Negative and Neutral Co-Pairs in Virtual Reality. *UBC Psychology Undergraduate Research Conference*.

Poster (2023) – Safi, O.K., Shi, E., Madan, C. R., Palombo, D.J. - Immersive affective dilation: Investigating temporal-duration for emotional events using virtual reality. *International Conference on Learning and Memory*.

Poster (2023) – Safi, O.K., Shi, Y., Lin, L., Madan, C. R., Palombo, D.J. - A Novel Virtual Reality Paradigm for Inducing Emotion. *Society for Affective Science Annual Conference*.

Poster (2023) – Yu, T., Safi, O.K., Kryklywy, J. H., Palombo, D.J. - Creating a Database of Affective Stimuli for Virtual Reality Research. *UBC Psychology Undergraduate Research Conference*.

Poster (2022) – Safi, O.K., Kryklywy, JH, Todd, RM, Palombo, D.J. - Investigating the effects of emotion on temporal duration memory using naturalistic virtual reality. *Society for Affective Science Annual Conference*.

Poster (2022) – Safi, O.K., Bontkes, O, Palombo, D.J.- Assessing the perceptual characteristics of emotional and non-emotional simulations using Natural Language Processing. *Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference.*

Poster (2022) – Yiran, S, Safi, O.K., Palombo, D.J. - Transfer of Valence in Virtual Reality. *UBC Psychology Undergraduate Research Conference.*

Talk (2020) – Safi, O.K. - Carbon Footprint Information Promotes Sustainable Food Choices. Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference.

Poster (2020) – Safi, O.K., Li, A.C., Cheng, A.F., Schuetz, C.G. - Assessing Cue-Induced Craving in Individuals with Methamphetamine Addiction Through Portable EEG Technology. *Department of Psychiatry 2020 Virtual Research Day.*

Poster (2020) – Safi, O.K. - Climate Change, Affect, and The Overview Effect. *UBC Psychology Undergraduate Research Conference.*

*Poster accepted but conference cancelled due to Covid-19

SCHOLARLY REVIEW

Ad Hoc Reviewer – Emotion (November 2024). Assisted supervisor with review

Ad Hoc Reviewer – Cognition (December 2021). Assisted supervisor with review

Ad Hoc Reviewer – Behavior Research Methods (March 2022). Assisted supervisor with review

TEACHING ASSISTANTSHIPS

- Psyc 102: Introduction to Developmental, Social, Personality, and Clinical Psychology (Dr. Mark Lam, 01-04/2026)
- Psyc 333: Memory: Historical, Clinical, & Cognitive Perspectives (Dr. Daniela Palombo, 09-12/2025)
- Psyc 102: Introduction to Developmental, Social, Personality, and Clinical Psychology (Dr. Andrew Rivers, 05-06/2025)
- Psyc 311: Psychology of Sport (Jeff Sauve, 01-04/2025)
- Psyc 311: Psychology of Sport (Jeff Sauve, 09-12/2024)
- Psyc 311: Psychology of Sport (Jeff Sauve, 05-06/2024)
- Psyc 309: Cognitive Processes (Dr. Daniela Palombo, 01-04/2024)
- Psyc 311: Psychology of Sport (Dr. Jeff Sauve, 09-12/2023)
- Psyc 309: Cognitive Processes (Dr. Daniela Palombo, 01-04/2023)
- Psyc 333: Memory: Historical, Clinical and Cognitive Perspectives (Dr. Daniela Palombo, 09-12/2022)
- Psyc 309: Cognitive Processes (Dr. Todd Handy, 09-12/2022)

- Psyc 307: Cultural Psychology (Dr. Benjamin Cheung, 01-04/2022)
- Psyc 309: Cognitive Processes (Dr. Daniela Palombo, 09-12/2021)

SUPERVISION AND MENTORING

Directed Studies:

- Ashton Thorpe
- Charles Lin
- Theodore Yu
- Akash Grewall

Psych 240*:

* An elective course aimed at helping students with no prior experience get involved in hands-on research experience in psychology for course credit.

- Julia Halfen
- Akash Grewall
- Theodore Yu

Research Assistants:

- Jasneet Sabrao
- Christy Wong
- Felisca Levana
- Sanjana Subramaniam
- Samriddhi Verma
- Maya Lehman
- Brigitte Browett
- Erin Chiu
- Aditya Sanghi
- Amber Geekee
- Daniel Simoes Brandao
- Devishi Mehra
- Julia Halfen
- Lavelle Liu

MEMBERSHIPS AND AFFILIATIONS

Cognitive Neuroscience Society: Member (2025/26)

Psychonomic Society: Member (2024-26)

Canadian Psychological Association: Member (2025/26)

Psychonomic Society: Member (2024 - 2026)

Spark Society: Member (2022 - Present)

Society for Affective Science: Member (2021 - 2023)

Cognitive Science Society: Member (2020 - Present)

Cognitive Systems Society: Member (2017-2020), Executive (2018-2020)
UBC Psychology Students Association: Member (2019-2020)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Graduate Student (MA)

2021-23

Memory and Imagination Lab – University of British Columbia

- Investigating recall of elapsed time for emotional and non-emotional contexts
- Investigating duration memory for emotional and non-emotional imagined future events
- Investigating duration memory for emotional events using virtual reality
- Developing and validating a novel set of emotional stimuli for use in virtual reality

Research Assistant

2020

Memory and Imagination Lab – University of British Columbia

- Investigating the relationship between emotion and temporal memory
- Examining relationship between emotional arousal and temporal proximity judgements
- Developing a study aiming to examine how emotion affects temporal judgements in episodic future thought

Tracking Independent Information Signals Across Brain Regions

2020

Motivated Cognition Lab – University of British Columbia

Supervisors: Dr. James Kryklywy and Dr. Rebecca Todd

- Project focused on methodological innovation for neuroimaging analysis
- Analysis of emotional and sensory communication information in the brain
- Statistical analyses and graphical representation using R
- Matrix manipulations in MATLAB
- Neuroimaging processing and displaying done in AFNI
- RSA script in Python

Senior Thesis*

2020

Behavioral Sustainability Lab - University of British Columbia

Motivated Cognition Lab – University of British Columbia

Supervisors: Dr. Jiaying Zhao and Dr. Rebecca Todd

*Data collection disrupted due to Covid-19

- Examining the affective responses produced by VR induced overview effect and its effect on climate change attitudes
- Produced novel idea of examining relationship between the overview effect and climate attitudes
- Conducted literature review
- Created study design and protocol
- Completed and obtained ethics approval (UBC BREB)
- Rendered stimulus in Unity – 3D Model of Earth

- Collect, record, and analyze subject data
 - Heart Rate, Galvanic Skin Response, and Questionnaires

Behavioral Sustainability Lab

2019-Present

University of British Columbia

- Worked on my senior thesis examining the consequences of the overview on climate change attitudes
- Completed and obtained ethics (UBC BREB)
- Dynamic model of Earth created in Unity
- Coded aspects of the environment in C# (atmosphere, cloud movement, earth rotation)
- Coded player movement scripts in C#
- Coded Oculus Rift headset and Oculus controller integration in C#
- Prepared surveys in Qualtrics measuring several psychological variables (PANAS-X, AWE-S, INS, Climate Concern)
- Learned use of Empatica E4 wristband to collect physiological data (Heart Rate & GSR)
- Learned to use QRSTool, an open source software, to analyze physiological data

Behavioral Reward Affect & Impulsivity Neuroscience (BRAIN) Lab

2019 - 2020

University of British Columbia

- Project focusing on using the MUSE (portable EEG headband) to assess implicit craving in clinical populations with concurrent stimulant use and mental disorders
- Project aiming to use the MUSE headband to identify a novel biomarker for craving and relapse
- Worked on ethics applications for new studies and add-ons for ongoing studies
- Presented poster at Psychiatry Research Day

Motivated Cognition Lab

2018 – Present

University of British Columbia

- Worked on study investigating the influence of physiological arousal on reward
- Head research assistant for experiment examining attentional biases and emotion
- Received supervision for senior thesis
- Learned proper EEG usage – electrode handling and running participants
- Learned EEG preprocessing and data analysis (EEGLAB & ERPLAB)
- Worked on project aiming to find a novel analysis technique for fMRI data
- Learned to use Analysis of Functional NeuroImages (AFNI) – an open source environment for processing and displaying fMRI data

SKILLS

Programming Languages: C, C#, Python, R, HTML/CSS, Java Script

Machine Learning: TensorFlow, Keras

Statistical Programs: R, SPSS, JASP, G-Power, Jamovi

Experimental Technology: PsychoPy, QRSTool, Afni (Neuroimaging), MATLAB, EEGLAB & ERPLAB, Qualtrics

Web Frameworks: WordPress, Weebly, Squarespace

Visual/Audio Programs: Unity, Unreal, Meshroom, Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Illustrator, Audacity

Natural Languages: English, Dari, Farsi, Hindi, Urdu, Spanish

CERTIFICATIONS

Computational Neuroscience Course Neuromatch Academy	2025
VCH Privacy and Confidentiality Vancouver Coastal Health	2019
Ethical Conduct for Research Involving Humans Tri-Council Policy Statement 2: CORE	2016

COMMUNITY AND VOLUNTEER ACTIVITIES

Session Chair Northwest Cognition and Memory (NOWCAM) Conference	2025/26
Cognitive Area Representative UBC Psychology Graduate Student Council	2025/26
Graduate Student Representative UBC Psychology EDI Committee	2024/25
Science Communication Lakehead University's 19 th Annual Research & Innovation Week's Community Outreach Event	2024/25
Cognitive Area Representative UBC Psychology Graduate Student Council	2024/25
Graduate Student Representative UBC Psychology Climate Action Committee Worked alongside faculty members to create a climate action plan aimed to lower department emissions in line with the broader goals of the university.	2023/24

Graduate Student Representative UBC Psychology Search Committee Evaluated applications for joint faculty position across Psychology and Computer Science departments.	2023
Cognitive Area Representative UBC Psychology Graduate Student Council	2022/23
Peer Mentor UBC Psychology Diversity Membership Program Provide professional development support and mentorship for students from historically underrepresented and/or diverse backgrounds	2022-24
Poster Judge UBC Psychology Undergraduate Research Conference Evaluated research posters at the department of psychology annual undergraduate research conference	2022